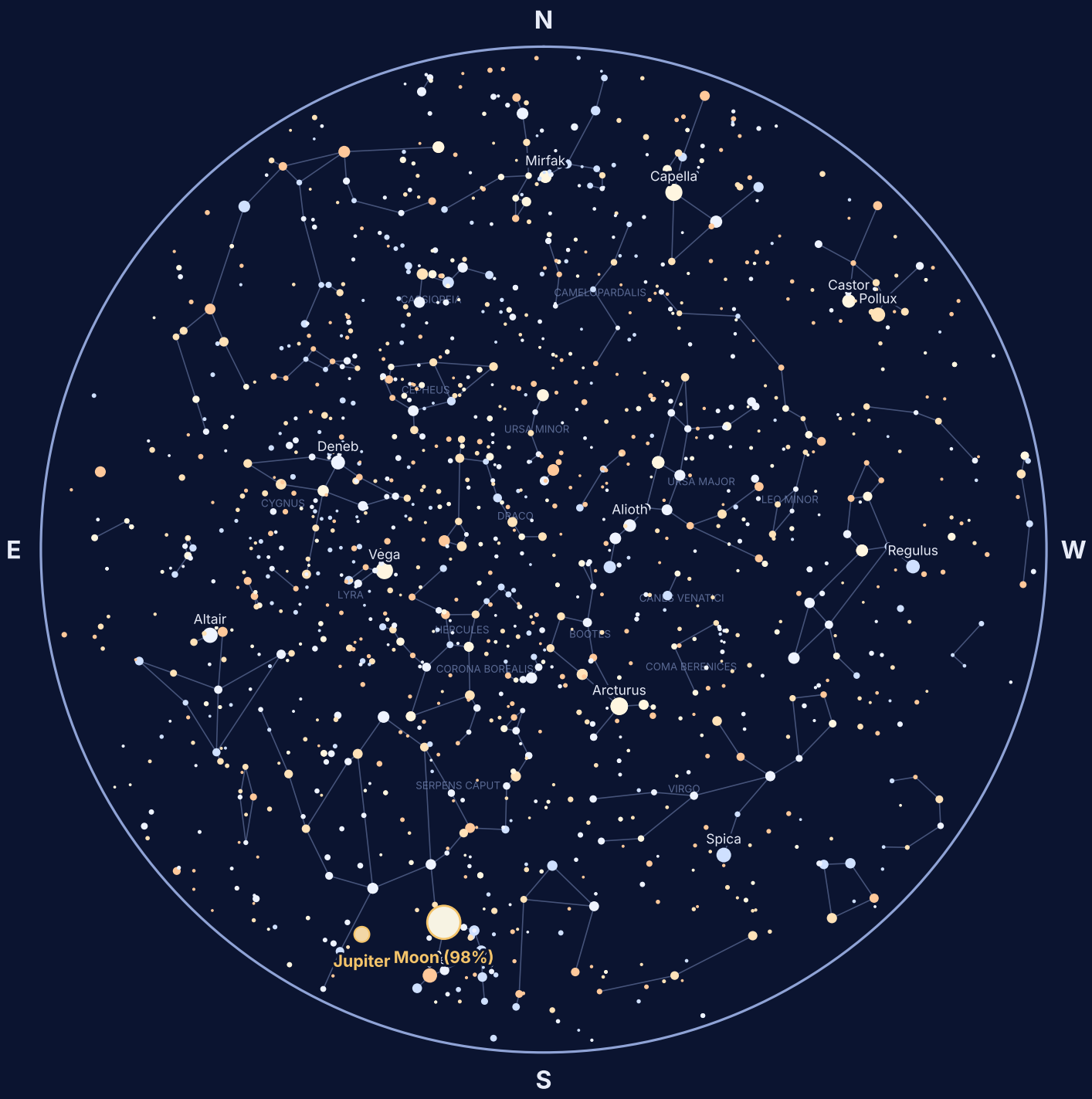
The night Sam and Alex were married

Edinburgh · Saturday 15 June 2019 · 23:00



The sky above Edinburgh, latitude 55.95°, longitude -3.20°

With love, from the sky.

A letter from the sky

This is a letter from the sky. It's about one night: Saturday, the fifteenth of June, twenty nineteen, in Edinburgh. It was the night Sam and Alex were married.

Nobody photographs the sky on nights like that. Everyone is looking somewhere else. So here is what was happening above you, worked out from the movements of the Earth, the Moon and the planets.

The Sun had set at ten o'clock at night.

The Moon was waxing gibbous, completely lit. It hung a little way up in the south, in front of the stars of Scorpius.

The planets were out too. Jupiter was low down in the south-east. Jupiter is the biggest planet of all. More than a thousand Earths could fit inside it.

Before dawn, Saturn would rise as well.

Among the stars, Arcturus was high up in the south-west. The light from Arcturus that shone on Edinburgh that night had left the star around nineteen eighty-two. Vega was high up in the east. The light from Vega that shone on Edinburgh that night had left the star around nineteen ninety-four. Altair was a little way up in the east. The light from Altair that shone on Edinburgh that night had left the star around two thousand and two.

Directly overhead was the constellation of Draco. Draco is a dragon, curling its long tail between the two bears near the top of the sky. The sky will never be arranged in exactly this way again. The Moon, the planets and the turning Earth will not line up like this for thousands of years.

But every year, around June, the same stars come back to the same places in the evening sky. So when you look up and find Arcturus, you are looking at the sky of that night. With love, from the sky.